

Nathaniel Olisa

Professor Megan Anaya

Econ 437

December 3, 2025

Inglewood, California, has become a laboratory of sports-driven economic development. The city, whose unemployment rate exceeded 17% in 2011, narrowly avoided bankruptcy in that year but has since rebranded itself as a “city of sports and entertainment” and jumped on the economic development bandwagon. After leveraging its infrastructure to land a new SoFi Stadium in 2016, Inglewood is now set to open Intuit Dome, a \$2 billion arena expected to house the NBA’s Los Angeles Clippers by 2024. The project is notable in part because stadium development has traditionally been treated with a fair amount of skepticism from an economic development perspective: prior work from NBER, Brookings, and the Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City has consistently shown that new stadiums have a minimal to negative net benefit for the local economy and nearby small businesses. In this case, however, the Intuit Dome deal is surrounded by a suite of historic community benefits agreements (CBAs) and community engagement efforts, including \$100 million in benefits (\$75 million for affordable housing) and requirements around local hiring and business development.

Considering Inglewood’s turnaround, the question is whether these community benefits and partnerships have translated into economic outcomes for the city. The geographic area of interest is Inglewood, a majority-Black and Latino city in Los Angeles County that has been described as one of the most underinvested cities in the region. If the Intuit Dome project has truly changed the city’s development trajectory, it would

provide a potentially replicable model in the era of equity-oriented economic development. However, if these policies have not measurably altered the city's trajectory, it may further confirm critics' concerns about sports-centric economic development.

The policy evaluation could track changes in employment and incomes, housing affordability, and small business revenues associated with the Intuit Dome, providing useful insights as new stadium developments are proposed in other cities. The analysis will cover both the buildout (prior to the arena opening) and early years of operation, using administrative datasets and ACS 5-Year Estimates at the city level and potentially with comparison to similar cities such as Hawthorne and Compton.

The quasi-experimental evaluation will take the form of a difference-in-differences (DD) design that uses both pre-and post-development trends from Inglewood and the other cities to establish a counterfactual of what Inglewood would have looked like without the Intuit Dome. The time period for the analysis is 2015–2025. The development was approved in 2016 and has ongoing buildout, with the arena expected to open in 2024. Community programs attached to the arena, such as the affordable housing bond and living wage policies, are set to ramp up in 2025.

The primary independent variable of interest is the Intuit Dome effect. The dependent variables of interest will include median household income, the percent of the population in poverty, and the number of people per household, which can be obtained from ACS 5-Year Estimates. The 2017–2021 ACS profile indicates baseline levels of income and poverty in Inglewood. Annual ACS data (e.g., 2018–2022) will be compared

to the latest year once available (e.g., 2024–2028) to detect mid- and long-term impacts after the development.

Annual unemployment rate and size of the labor force, taken from the California Employment Development Department (EDD) and the BLS LAUS program. Inglewood's unemployment rate has already fallen precipitously, from a high of 17% in 2011 to about 4.7% by 2019, but data from the post-pandemic recovery period will be compared to see whether new job growth in the city is above or below expected trends.

Annual rent estimates and housing permits and starts, which can be measured using Zillow's ZORI and ZHVI indices. These datasets are more granular (monthly, ZIP-code-level) than ACS and provide rent and home value inflation indicators. Median home price in Inglewood was at about \$740,000 in the third quarter of 2023, up nearly 8% year over year from Zillow's ZHVI. Rents have followed suit, growing to historic highs. Because housing is not currently constructed or financed at the local level in California, city governments often have a weak direct influence on housing markets. Rents are even more difficult to control without state or federal intervention. We will compare the city's rent growth to regional and peer benchmarks to see whether the development has affected renters (majority of Inglewood population) and whether the CBA's affordable housing provisions have measurably increased supply.

Tax revenues, small business licenses, and business establishment or violation counts from city administrative data, if available. This dataset would provide direct measures of economic activity and business growth from the development, including new businesses formed in the city or local contractors from Intuit Dome-related construction.

Work Cited

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